understanding, the charges of sedition against Tohra and Badal were withdrawn and they were released from jail on 11 May.

The last round of talks was held on 26 May and was conducted by External Affairs Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and two other cabinet ministers, with the help of the three-member think-tank, where T.N. Chaturvedi had now been replaced by M.M.K. Wali, the new home secretary. Tohra, still hopeful of becoming chief minister, met Bhindranwale to get his approval of the agreement, but Bhindranwale insisted on acceptance of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution in its full form.

How these talks failed is described at the end of Chapter 4. Amarinder Singh, who did not participate in the February talks nor this latest round, explained his reasons for non-participation to Mark Tully as follows, 'Mrs Gandhi's think-tank was too bureaucratic in its attitude to the demands for river water and Chandigarh, and did not understand the political pressure on the Akali leaders.' [16] With the last round of talks having failed, on 26 May 1984 Longowal announced a new programme to intensify the Akali agitation, starting from 3 June. This involved blocking transport of food grains from Punjab to other states, non-payment of taxes due to the government, and regular courting of arrest by Sikhs.

It was now time for the 1 Akbar Road group to reap the bitter harvest, the seeds of which had been sown in 1980. But before dealing with the next stage, Operation Blue Star, there are a few issues which need to be explained, to allow the reader to understand the developments in their correct perspective.